

TL;DR: Pathway Lab is a simulated chat platform for exploring teen peer conflict and ways to exit, repair, or seek help.

INTRODUCTION

In adolescent group chats, a joke, public comeback, or screenshot request can turn one peer into a target and invite others to join. Status, belonging, or prior hurt may make stepping back difficult. Pathway Lab asks how a simulated environment can help participants reason about a fictional sender’s situation, consider effects on the target and group, and identify an exit, repair, or escalation route.

PATHWAYS → REDIRECTION

Literature-informed design synthesis. We organized developmental and public-health concepts [5–9] into eight frames, then translated each into a fictional chat with possible pressure, target/group impact, and redirection options.

FRAME / CONTEXT

REDIRECTION OPTION

Status-seeking

Gaining peer approval

Keep humor; remove the personal target

Control-seeking

Silencing or excluding

Set boundaries without excluding

Retaliation

Hitting back after hurt

Defend without public humiliation

Bully-victim transfer

Passing on prior harm

Protect yourself without targeting others

Learned aggression

Using familiar hostile scripts

Be direct without degrading

Moral disengagement

Treating harm as “just a joke”

Recognize impact; stop repeating harm

Group pile-on

Joining or sustaining harm

Leave the pile-on; stop sharing

Post-harm repair

Responding after harm

Stop the spread; take responsibility

Escalation boundary Severe or repeated harm → trusted adult, school, or platform support.

Scenario 1 · Status-seeking joke. Draft: “She should never speak again. That was painful.”
Exit: “That presentation was rough, but I do not want to pile on.”

CONTRIBUTION

A reusable pathway grammar. Eight literature-grounded scenarios connect a risky draft’s possible pressure and group impact to distinct next steps: a safer next message, accountable repair after harm, or escalation for severe cases. Our contribution is this inspectable mapping and a scripted environment for third-person critique. Participants interpret first, then accept, reject, or rewrite support; pressure labels describe possible situations, not diagnoses.

[1] Katsaros et al. (2022). [2] DiFranzo et al. (2019). [3] Zou et al. (2024). [4] Agha et al. (2023). Frames: [5] StopBullying.gov (2021, 2025); [6] Hensums et al. (2023); [7] Estévez et al. (2020); [8] Zhao & Yu (2021); [9] CDC (2025).

RELATED WORK

Posting-time prompts encourage reconsideration [1], and teen co-design motivates real-time nudges for risk perpetrators [4]. TestDrive provides simulated digital citizenship learning [2]; Co-pilot supports witnesses acting as upstanders [3]. Pathway Lab builds on these approaches by linking a sender’s or joiner’s draft to group harm and distinct exit, repair, and escalation options.

THE DESIGN PROBE

B Compare the Lens
Pressure → impact → next step

B Pathway Lens
Scripted scaffold for reflection

1 **Possible pressure**
One interpretation, not a diagnosis.

STATUS-SEEKING
Make people laugh
This draft may be trying to keep status or momentum in the group. The participant can accept, reject, or revise that reading.

2 **Target and group impact**
Translate the draft from different positions.

Sender
For Alex, this may feel like a quick joke that keeps the chat moving.

Target
To the classmate, it may read as the group deciding they are embarrassing, not just that one presentation was rough.

Group
Others may treat the message as permission to keep escalating, even if nobody planned that at first.

3 **Choose the next step**
Exit first when possible; repair or escalate when needed.

☒ **Social exit**
That presentation was rough, but I do not want to pile on.

☐ **Repair**
Delete the message or stop it from spreading.

☐ **Escalation**
Escalate if the group keeps targeting the same person, shares recordings, uses identity-based insults, or moves toward threats.

► Other possible exits

☒ Participant decides: compare the lens with your own read, then accept, reject, or rewrite.

A Read the chat and Alex’s draft first.
Then compare the scripted support.

C Reflect + respond
Accept, reject, or rewrite; explain your choice.

Scenario Information
Scenario 1 of 8
Status-seeking joke
A group chat is discussing a classmate’s awkward class presentation. Several peers are already making jokes.

Task role
Help Alex decide what to do next.

Important
All names, messages, and situations are fictional. No personal experiences are requested.

Progress 1 / 8 scenarios
< Previous Next >

Simulated Group Chat
5 online

M Maya Joking
That presentation was hard to watch.

N Noah Joking
The pause after slide 3 felt like a year.

A Ari Neutral
I laughed but I also felt bad.

S Sam Neutral
We are all bad at this, but yeah.

Alex is typing a message...

Draft message from Alex:
She should never speak again. That was painful.

A Your first read
Write a short note before comparing with scripted support.
What pressure might be shaping this draft? What harm could it create?

The pathway lens is scripted support, not an answer key.

C Reflection checkpoint
Questions about Alex’s next step

1. **Your interpretation**
☒ Make people laugh
☐ Get group approval
☐ Give feedback
☐ Make one person the target
☐ Not sure

2. **Recommended next step**
☐ That presentation was rough, but I do not want to pile on.
Or write your own safer response...

3. **Agency check**
☐ I made my own read before comparing support.
☐ The pathway lens leaves room to disagree.
☐ I can explain why this next step is safer.

CURRENT EVIDENCE

Scripted design probe; effects untested.

Next: expert review and IRB-approved teen studies of interpretation, reasoning, and perceived agency.